

## Jazz as a Protest

The atmosphere which has surrounded jazz almost since the beginning is so overcharged with emotion as to make it extremely difficult to explain in purely musical terms. The first English writer to deal seriously, if inadequately, with jazz, R. W. S. Mendl, observed this as early as 1926. Unlike earlier light music, he noted, jazz was actively disliked and ‘subject to the most violent and slashing attacks’,<sup>1</sup> and this, he thought, probably accounted for the failure of any composer of the front rank to take it up. It was so strongly disliked, he argued, because it ‘upset’ us more and stirred us emotionally more than older kinds of light music had done. So it does, but the upsetting is by no means only musical.

Let us simply consider the extraordinary fervour which jazz has been able to rouse fairly consistently among its devotees, and which leads young jazz-lovers to treat famous musicians as something like models, heroes, or saints, and more mature ones to leap over the barriers of non-musical loyalty with astonishing ease. Lt Dietrich Schulz-Koehn of the German army spent his war leaves in Paris working on the 1942 edition of M. Delaunay’s *Hot Discography*, though the French jazz-lovers’ community was, for obvious reasons, extremely anti-German. When captured at Lorient he interrupted the negotiations for the surrender of the local German troops by asking whether anyone collected Benny Goodman records. It is difficult to see the devotees of other widespread international hobbies pursuing their passion quite so far. Again, the views of the Soviet authorities on jazz have been known at least since the middle 1930s. They disliked it, and regarded it (sometimes not unjustifiably) as a phenomenon of bourgeois decadence. When views on such matters were expressed by the leaders of world Socialism, Communists in Western countries normally assumed that they were sensible or justifiable and often made extraordinary efforts to convince

themselves and others of this, sometimes in the teeth of their own previous liking for, say, Rilke, Braque, or Alban Berg. At all events they normally made few attempts to express contrary views in public. Yet it is no exaggeration to say that no Communist jazz-lover—and there has been a disproportionately large number of them—has ever taken serious notice of Soviet hostility to his music. This was regarded as an aberration, due to ignorance, or at best as something due to purely local Russian conditions, an attitude which Communists might profitably have adopted on other questions also. So far from taking notice of Russian views, British Communist journals printed serious jazz reviews continuously even in the peak years of ‘Zhdanovism’. Clearly, jazz rouses remarkably powerful and tenacious emotions among both its supporters and opponents.

In this chapter I wish to suggest that this is due to the fact that jazz is not simply an ordinary music, light or heavy, but also a music of protest and rebellion. It is not necessarily or always a music of conscious and overt *political* protest, let alone any particular brand of political protest; though in the West, in so far as it has had political links, they have been pretty invariably with the left. (It is hard to see how it could be otherwise, since even the most apolitical jazz-lover must be committed to opposing racial discrimination, which is publicly defended only on the right.) But a good many of the protests and rebellions which jazz has at one time or another embodied leave politicians cold and unsympathetic. The French boys and girls who, in 1942, were arrested by the Germans in the Paris Métro dressed in ‘flash, impertinent, provocative suits and dresses, and wearing a badge with the words “*une France swing dans une Europe zazoue*”,’ can only just be fitted into the category of the anti-Nazi resistance, even though several of the poor things ended in labour camps.<sup>2</sup> Such protests may become political because the people against whom jazz-lovers protest (for instance, fathers, mothers, uncles, and aunts) happen to hold certain conventional views, some of which are political (for instance, Republicanism in the U.S.A. Or they may be labelled subversive chiefly because those against whom they are directed cannot conceive of a rebellion against some of their conventions as anything but a rebellion against all their views: for example, as ‘un-

American'. The point is not that the jazz protests can be fitted into this or that pigeonhole of orthodox politics, though it often can—mostly into a left-wing one—but that the music lends itself to any kind of protest and rebelliousness much better than most other forms of the arts. There is historic justice in the story of the seven striking Nottinghamshire miners who, at the end of 1926, were fined £3 each for 'forming a jazz band' and making life difficult with it for a blackleg.<sup>3</sup> It is a music for expressing strong feelings of dislike.

This is due, in the first place, to an element jazz shares, alas, with Tin Pan Alley: it is democratic music. As the organ of the British popular musicians wrote in one of its first editorials, at the beginning of a career of consistent and passionate championship of jazz:

Jazz is a new cult. It is probably a grand new art, and it has this advantage over 'straight' music that it appeals not only to the fauteuils but to the gallery also. It considers no class distinction.

Jazz was originally music designed to be enjoyed by the least intellectual or expert, the least privileged, educated, or experienced citizen, as well as by others; though the specialist jazz aficionados have been much more reluctant to admit this than the players. It was also designed to be played by men who have 'picked it up' any way. The jazz listener does not require the sort of preparation which is needed to listen profitably to a fugue, the jazz player can perform without the sort of training which is needed to sing coloratura, though this does not mean that either fails to benefit from training. More than this: jazz is a musical manifesto of populism. *The Merry Widow* might be the musically modest citizen's grand opera, but the jazz band, real or pseudo, was in no sense an imitation of a culturally more ambitious or respectable genre. Loud, raucous, sounding (even without the pseudo-jazz additions of tin pans, motor horns, and funny hats) like nothing on Earth except an undisciplined brass band playing in a room too small for it, the pioneer jazz band nailed the colours of its 'vulgarity' firmly to the mast. It appeared not simply because people liked the sound, but because it was a conquest of popular over minority culture, like that of the Marx Brothers

who break up a performance of Grand Opera by getting the band to play *Take Me Out to the Ballgame*.

Several things may flow from such populism, good and bad: for those of us who are for popular art as for popular government must be prepared to recognize its considerable drawbacks. At its best the democracy of jazz produced an ideal of art in society wider and socially sounder than that of the orthodox minority culture, though recognizing and admiring its achievements. For instance, it gave people who, in terms of classical music, would have been doomed to remain pure listeners or simple executants, the chance actually to make (i.e. to create, not merely to reproduce) music. It has produced scholarship and serious critical discussion of art among people whom the orthodox arts could never bring to this point: audiences whom gossip columnists contemptuously describe as 'not the most intelligent that have been seen', who listen, with absolute attention, in absolute silence, and in their thousands, to what would in orthodox terms be considered a reasonably difficult chamber-music recital; and what is more, who discuss them as the old Viennese musical public would discuss the rival merits of Furtwängler and Bruno Walter. It has come nearer to breaking down class lines than any other art. At least I know of no other which could produce a table full of sax players from a West Indian orphanage, American soldiers from a black neighbourhood in Cleveland, journalists, dons, salesmen, and souteneurs single-mindedly debating the stylistic differences between the East and West coast schools of jazz. At its best the democratic protest of jazz merely means that this music stakes a claim to a serious participation in the arts for people who would, but for it, be mostly debarred from such participation; and its appeal for such people is therefore strong.

At its worst it degenerates into philistinism. For if jazz is designed for the least intellectual or expert, the least prepared, privileged, or experienced citizens as well as for others, this also means that it appeals to the most stupid, ignorant, lazy, and inexpert, who do not like what they cannot understand, or what requires effort, or knowledge, or expertise. It is true that this sort of philistinism surrounds the jazz-influenced kinds of pop music much more than jazz itself, whose strict devotees are generally shocked by the prospect of simply sitting back and enjoying themselves; the critics more than the musicians. The Hollywood films in which the

hero, after a disgusted flirtation with 'long-hair' music, lifts the saxophone to his lips, pushes his body into convulsions, and finds the girl, the money, and the way forward, are about the stars of Tin Pan Alley. For these the contempt of the strict jazz public is often as boundless as that of the classicist. But if jazz *has* influenced and coloured pop music to the extent it has, it is largely because the pop public took so readily to an idiom which flaunted its 'vulgarity'; for exactly the same reason that *Take Me Out to the Ballgame* played in the middle of Grand Opera sounds much more 'outrageous' when played by a brass band than by a string orchestra. Nor is it any use denying that even many jazzmen have regarded their music not as an addition to serious music but as a straight competitor to the 'classics'.

In the second place jazz is a music of protest, because it was originally the music of an oppressed people and of oppressed classes: of the latter perhaps more obviously than of the former, though the two cannot be kept rigidly separate. It has, of course, made perhaps its most powerful appeal to middle- and upper-class aficionados because of these social origins: nobody has ever started a movement of emotional commitment to Czerny's exercises, which are not less interesting than some boogie-woogie piano (though in a different way), because nobody has ever felt like idealizing the nineteenth-century lower-middle classes *en masse*. But blacks have been so idealized, much to their justified disgust.

The belief that the American black in some sense represented desirable elements which white civilization lacked has been widespread in America and Britain since the black-faced minstrel shows first became a standard type of popular entertainment in the second third of the nineteenth century. The search for the pure, the innocent, the 'natural' counterpart of modern Western bourgeois society is as old as that society itself, for it reflects the permanent awareness of its fundamental flaws. Sometimes it took the form of simple exoticism and primitivism: the search for the noble savage, who might be located, according to taste, in Tahiti or the Corsican highlands, in the Caucasus or on the Arabian deserts. Sometimes, especially among members of the middle and upper classes, it took the more complex form of a sort of partial idealization of social groups who were, in other respects, hated, despised, and

oppressed: workers (especially unskilled ones) and peasants, women, social outcasts like criminals and prostitutes, oppressed pariah peoples like blacks and gypsies. In such cases admiration was mixed with contempt, sometimes with fear which is often only an unacknowledged form of admiration for something we cannot do ourselves. The gypsy was filthy, thieving, superstitious, and treacherous, but 'spontaneous' and 'free' as in Mérimée and Bizet's *Carmen*, which is the textbook example of this attitude; the Southern black is for William Faulkner a rightly dominated subman, but also, by his very strength, emotional fervour, and 'simplicity' a sort of reproach.\* Among the more rebellious minorities, mainly of intellectuals and artists, the idealization was much more simple: the milieu of gangsters, pimps, and prostitutes, as represented in, say, Becker's film *Casque d'or*, was quite simply more heroic, free, innocent, and in its roundabout way, just *because* it was one of outcasts and protesters against social convention. In terms of jazz, jazz is good music because it is believed to derive not simply from blacks but from the red-light district of New Orleans.

The emotional, and often quite irrational, bias in favour of blacks and black low life has always been extremely strong among serious jazz-lovers. Politically left-wing aficionados have attempted to counter it with the argument that jazz is a people's music of both black and white oppressed, though for historic reasons the blacks have formed and advanced it most, and practised it best, and for sociological ones the low-life zone of large cities has provided its best nurseries. But though this view has won some intellectual assent, at least when not put forward in its more extremist forms, it has not really disturbed the fundamental 'black' bias of most of the older jazz-lovers.<sup>4</sup> This bias, especially among some traditionalist zealots, can reach the point of mania as when one (white) historian of jazz writes that 'white men cannot even play it', or another argues that:

I may say that authentic jazz can be created only by Negroes; any other jazz by white men ... is not authentic. They cannot emulate the feeling and expression of their Negro contemporaries, because

they are alien to the mystical and profound inspirations which motivate the Negro musician.<sup>5</sup>

The desire to become a 'white Negro', of which Mezzrow's *Really the Blues* is the best literary expression, is merely the most extreme form of this attitude. It may be as well to remember that this is merely an inverted version of the more orthodox type of racialism, such as that of the people 'whose hostile reaction to syncopated dance music is attributed by them to everything connected with the nigger'.<sup>6</sup> The fact that the one attitude leads to civilized behaviour between peoples and the other to Nazi or South African barbarism should not obscure the equal irrationality of both. A good deal of jazz criticism is permeated by less extreme versions of the same pro-black race feeling, and this sometimes affects critical standards.

Colour prejudice in reverse (what black intellectuals used to call 'Crow Jim') must not be confused with the obvious recognition, which implies no belief in mysticism or blood, that the origins and evolution of jazz are more closely linked with the history of American blacks than with any other group of people, and that up to the present the supremacy of black players in jazz is about as obvious and perhaps even more unchallenged than that of Jews in chess playing. (Of course it may be argued that this is partly due to the practice of critics, since about 1930, of establishing the criteria of good jazz in terms of the achievements of black players, but I do not think the general superiority of, say, Armstrong, Bessie Smith, and Charlie Parker over any of their white contemporaries and predecessors can be wholly explained away in this manner.) The point I wish to make is not that the role of blacks in jazz has been exaggerated, for it has not; but that the appeal of jazz for many white middle-class admirers is that it is a music of those who, by middle-class ranking, are socially below them. The lady leaves her castle with the raggle-taggle gypsies, not because they play so sweet, but because they are *not* ladies and gentlemen—they are in fact gypsies.

Apart from this, the protesting element in jazz owes less than one might suppose to its actual black character. For, paradoxically, the black's own musical protest against his fate was one of the less important

elements in the appeal of jazz, and one of the latest to become influential. All American blacks, like all members of oppressed and underprivileged peoples everywhere, are always protesting against their situation in one way or another, by the very modes of their behaviour, even if not consciously and deliberately. However, in times of relative political stability such as those when jazz was evolved, such protests are often indirect, allusive, complex, esoteric, and extremely difficult for outsiders to recognize as protests, because they are not addressed to them. Jewish jokes, often of a type which, if told by an outsider, would be regarded as anti-semitic, are an extremely elaborate form of expressing resentment against the old ghetto Jews' position, but quite unadapted to become the basis of rebelliousness by non-Jews. Just so the innumerable self-deprecating in-group allusions of traditional Southern black culture are likely to be regarded by outsiders, and indeed by politically more advanced blacks, not as protests but as 'Uncle Tomism'. And not wholly without reason, for one of the functions of such protests is to blow off steam without producing the explosions—lynchings and pogroms—which incautious practical rebelliousness might always provoke. At all events, the early phase of jazz, which is the one with the greatest general influence, the 'New Orleans style' and its derivations and dilutions, is almost certainly the socially best 'adjusted' music ever evolved by American blacks, the product of a cruel and unjust society, but one in which the black was allowed considerable emotional certainty and security so long as he 'kept his place' within the ghetto where he played for other blacks. 'Unembattled, happy, almost complacent' is not a bad description of old-style New Orleans jazz.<sup>7</sup> This did not last, but its influence on white pop music, serious jazz, and the jazz public cannot be described as one of social protest. Only in the fervour of the spirituals and in the heart-breaking, but unselfpitying blues, did a note of genuine protest sound. But the vogue for these did not make substantial progress until the socially conscious 1930s.

But even the unembattled kind of common people's music has the elements of protest in it; nor are these confined to the black people. It is not only their type of music which speaks directly from and to the ordinary untrained man or woman, in which people play as men speak, or

laugh, or cry, only more so; and which, by virtue of this directness is a standing protest against the cultural and social orthodoxies from which it is so sharply distinct. It is any music *specifically* made by and for the poor, which however little intention of political protest. This may be illustrated by the example of an institution which has affinities with art and, incidentally, has had the most profound influence on the evolution of jazz, the 'poor man's church'.

The labouring poor have often, in Protestant countries, developed their own kinds of religion separate from, and in some respects opposed to, those of the upper classes.<sup>8</sup> These almost invariably have certain characteristics. They play down the things at which poor and ignorant people are bad—for instance, intellectualism, elaborate theologies, and the like—and stress those in which they compete on equal and superior terms—for instance, emotional fervour, moral enthusiasm, austerity. The educated preacher who appealed to Episcopalian and Presbyterian congregations among the New England (or Midland) middle classes, was unpopular among frontiersmen, mill-hands, miners, or sailors, who admired the man or woman who punched the Bible and preached blood and hell-fire in the style of the hot-gospelling actor-orator-singer. Every poor man's Protestant sect, white or black, is essentially a 'ranting' sect, whether it consists of Durham Primitive Methodists in the nineteenth century, or hillbilly Baptists, or the modern Pentecostal Holiness churches, Adventists, and Jehovah's Witnesses. Again, such sects were much given to democracy. The congregation took an active part in the proceedings, by choral singing, amens, and hallelujahs, by 'speaking with voices' and 'testifying' whenever the spirit moved a member, not to mention other means. The official gap between the preacher and the public was as small as possible, and the actual gap was no larger, since virtually any member who was 'moved' and had fervour and eloquence—and who has not, at certain moments?—could become a preacher himself or herself. Again, for very much the same reasons, religious worship was unformalized and unritualized, spontaneous and collective. Once again these characteristics appear in their purest form in black churches, and may be heard on the invaluable records of their services and music, but they may equally be found in white ones of whatever nationality,

provided these reflect similar social situations. Such religion, even when not intended as a social or political gesture, *was* a protest. Every element in it exalted the ways and aspirations of the poor, the ignorant and oppressed, the labourers, and depreciated the standards of the rich, the educated, the powerful, the upper ranks.

The parallel of such church services with primitive jazz is not arbitrary, even if we leave out of account the very close links between the ‘hot-gospelling’ black churches and the rhythmic blues, which makes a childhood among the Pentecostal Holiness people or the Churches of God in Christ so valuable an education for the future jazz musician. Like such churches, jazz was systematically *not* like orthodox culture, and exalted the gifts and ways of untrained and ignorant musicians and dancer-listeners in very similar ways. Like them, it went ‘straight to the heart’ of ordinary people, because its technique was designed to do so. The most remarkable technical achievement of the blues, its capacity to sweep the listener to the right emotional mood literally within the first bar, sometimes by the first note, is one it shares with the gospel song. The techniques of the hot-gospeller in prose, of the gospel singer in song, and of the improvising soloist in jazz are (as the word ‘hot’ implies) fundamentally similar. These techniques have only occasional parallels in the orthodox arts, which rely on a much more elaborate and complex system of gears and transmission belts between the artist’s emotion and its artistic expression. Only when we get an artist (himself, by the way, also a poor man’s evangelist) like Van Gogh, who aims at immediate impact of emotion, do we find a procedure analogous to jazz.

But its very nature and origins jazz therefore expresses some kinds of protest and heterodoxy and lends itself to the expression of others. The mere fact that it originates among oppressed and unconsidered people, and is looked down upon by orthodox society, can make the simple listening to jazz records into a gesture of social dissent; perhaps—as generations of teenagers have discovered—the cheapest of all such gestures. What they would do if jazz were ever to become domesticated and officially accepted, like ballet, makes for entertaining speculation.

I do not propose to survey the various kinds of protest which jazz has helped to express in the course of its history.<sup>±</sup> The subject has been

treated by psychologists, and may be left to them. My object has been to show, not why people require some way of making musical protests, or blowing off steam, but why, having these requirements, they should find jazz so eminently suitable. It is because it is 'common people's music', which, both by its social origins and associations and by its musical peculiarities, lends itself to such interpretation even where it is not designed for it. If jazz had not been on the American scene, some other form of the American popular tradition would unquestionably have come to take its place as a vehicle for protest, though hillbilly songs, cowboy music, or the vigorous and 'democratic' products of the early, half-folky Tin Pan Alley, would not have made perfect substitutes. For jazz owes at least this to its black origins and associations, that it is not merely 'common people's music', but common people's music at its most concentrated and emotionally powerful. Because blacks are and were oppressed even among the poor and powerless, their cries of protest are more poignant and more overwhelming, their cries of hope are more earth-shaking, than other peoples', and have found, even in words, the most unanswerable expression: 'Nobody knows the trouble I've seen', 'Sometimes I feel like a motherless child', 'Good morning, blues, Blues, how do you do?' Because the musical language of jazz is Afro-American, it is more heterodox, and owes less even to the echoes of orthodoxy than other kinds of popular music. Moreover, because of its musical origins, it has used that most potent of musical devices for inducing powerful physical emotion, rhythm, as no other music familiar to our society has. It is not merely a voice of protest: it is a natural loudspeaker.

What jazz protests about or against is, for our purposes, secondary. The protests which white intellectual Californian tramps, or British teenagers, or Johannesburg Africans, or Moscow *stilyagi*, seek to express through it differ from one another, and from those of various groups of American blacks. They are also, incidentally, of unequal seriousness. It would be foolish to reduce them all to a single denominator. They do, however, have this in common. Jazz *by itself* is not politically conscious or revolutionary. The voice of men shouting 'We do not like this' must not be misunderstood for the cry of 'This cannot last', let alone for the slogan 'This must be revolutionized'. Nor should artistic unorthodoxy be held to imply unorthodoxy all round, any more than the thief's

unorthodoxy about the criminal law implies unconventional views about politics. In fact, until adopted by groups of intellectuals, jazz has lent itself to political revolutionism rather less well than other kinds of popular music, for instance, religious hymns. There is a sound reason for this.

The origins of jazz lay among that section of the poor which, though extremely oppressed, is least given to collective organization and political consciousness, and which finds its 'freedom' by side-stepping oppression rather than by facing it; the unskilled, pre-industrial, big-city labouring poor. Being poor and oppressed, they sing and play about poverty and oppression as a matter of course. Folk-song experts of the left have never had any difficulty in discovering flamenco songs expressing bitter hatred of policemen and judges, Neapolitan ballads idealizing brigand-rebels, or blues of left-wing social significance. But equally, they have never been able to deny that the great majority of such songs, however persistent the undertone of resentment against poverty and oppression, are songs of private life and personal relations: the characteristic blues is and remains the song of the troubles between a woman and her man or a man and his woman. In a sense the strength of the slums, the brothels, the music halls, as nurseries of the popular arts derives from the fact that those who live in them and frequent them have no other *regular* outlet for their unhappiness than the making and experiencing of aesthetic impressions, 'living for kicks', as the phrase goes. For those who organize and fight, ecstasy is often a by-product of collective action, art a part of it, like the choral song, which, as hymn or in a secular form, is so characteristic of such movements, with their frequent—possibly their general—tendency to puritanism. But jazz is anti-puritan, and the choral song plays no part whatever in it. It is the critics who have classified secular jazz and blues and the gospel song under the same heading: historically and socially the 'gospel people' among the blacks have been strongly opposed to jazz and all it stood for, many jazz musicians and blues singers resentful and contemptuous of church groups. In much the same way the labour movements of Britain have generally been unenthusiastic about the old music halls, while the old music hall artists, in spite of their marked prejudice for the poor against the rich, were rarely political militants. The old British contrast

between the 'pub miner' (who was, more often than not, the less organized type) and the 'chapel miner' (who provided the cadre of union organizers) has its less formalized parallels in the world of jazz. Few politically militant blacks were genuine admirers of jazz, at least until it had been borne in upon them (often by the propaganda of white intellectuals) that this music was 'an achievement of the race' of which blacks should be proud.

It was easy to associate jazz with radical and revolutionary politics, and in times of political ferment American jazz musicians were quite willing so to be associated: after all, if the poor, however unorganized and demoralized, have any politics, they must be 'on the side of the poor'. (In other countries, where the jazz movement had different social bases and often grew out of the political left, the links were sometimes closer.) However, when left to itself, the jazz protest remained vague and ambiguous, because what it is against is far clearer than what it is for. It is against oppression, against poverty, against inequality and unfreedom, against unhappiness. It is, in a vague and anarchic way which has been misunderstood by the anarchist intellectuals who have taken jazz to their bosoms, against policemen and judges, prisons, armies, and war. (There are no traditional blues in praise of battle, however pacific; only spirituals.) The hatred of these things does not imply militancy. Very many American jazz musicians have expressed hatred and resentment of an unjust society, if only privately. Very few have been associated even with the active and organized fight against racial inequality in the way in which a good many prominent figures from more commercial popular entertainment—notably from Hollywood—have been.<sup>±</sup> Europe in the post-1945 period has known many American intellectual and artistic expatriates; but though several black players have settled here, largely because they are treated with greater human dignity in the old world, I cannot think of any 'political' jazz refugees of either colour to set beside the numerous 'political' refugees from Hollywood or New York in the other fields of art.

What jazz is *against* may be reasonably clear in theory, though it may find only a rather passive, evasive, and individualist expression outside music. The most notable of such expressions are perhaps the savage

diatribes of the jazz-steeped night-club satirists who became prominent in the later fifties, Mort Sahl, Lennie Bruce, and the rest. What it is *for* is much less clear. No doubt, liberty, equality, fraternity, and a chicken in the pot every Sunday, or every day, allowing for the American standard of living. However, these great slogans are less self-explanatory than even some who are not jazz musicians or jazz fans believe. And this has always beset the protest of jazz, like a good many other individualist and spontaneous protests, with a great temptation: that of settling for very small positive gains—for official recognition, for personal satisfaction. Or, to be more precise, of oscillating between a discontent which can never be satisfied because, like the ‘blue flower’ of the German romantics or the crock of gold at the foot of the rainbow, it is so defined as to be beyond satisfaction, and one which can be rather easily satisfied, by growing up, by being sent on a tour as ‘cultural ambassador’ for the U.S. Government, by playing with the New York Philharmonic, or earning a lot of money.

The yearning for official recognition is perhaps the most dangerous part of this temptation, because it affects not only the general appeal of jazz but also the music. It has always existed, even when the jazz players were perfectly content to blow out their souls as ordinary entertainers of a popular dancing audience, and the fans most vociferous in their contempt for the ‘long-hair’ arts. It is this which has caused jazz musicians of all styles time and again to insist on playing with string sections (for violins symbolize accepted cultural status in music), in spite of the uniformly disastrous results of such experiments. The film *St Louis Blues*, which, like so many American films, is a compendium of widely accepted fictions, all equally miserable, illustrates this very clearly: like the film about Louis Armstrong’s world tour, it ends in the apotheosis of jazz being played in a Philharmonic auditorium by a lot of fiddlers.<sup>§</sup> The rebels of the arts in jazz settle for admission to their version of the Royal Academy, unlike the rebels in more sophisticated arts, who have learned better. Similarly, jazz-lovers in both Britain and America have shown quite disproportionate resentment against the neglect of their music by the guardians of orthodox sound. Generations of them have grown up to repeat the same rare crumbs of praise for jazz by classical musicians

(first-or second-rate), and to hail with touching gratitude the occasional recognition of jazz by the Third Programme of the BBC or similar established cultural institutions.<sup>4</sup> The jazz fan, the jazz critic, have hitherto been hunted creatures. Few books about jazz fail to begin with, or to contain, a defence of jazz against its detractors.

This feeling of inferiority, whether acknowledged or not, has been part of the jazz protest. It has produced such phenomena as the attempt to turn jazz into something equivalent to 'straight music'—the 'symphonic jazz' of the 1920s, the devices lifted from Bach and Milhaud in modern jazz, the dressing up in morning coats and acknowledging applause by stiff bows, the systematic refusal to behave in any way like an old-fashioned extrovert entertainer. All this is understandable, perhaps inevitable, but it is to be regretted, for the strength of jazz is not the strength of the feeling of inferiority among its musicians or admirers, but that of an idiom which is, however limited, radically different from the orthodox minority culture. The British stage did not necessarily become better because actors have come to be given knighthoods. In one sense, the influx of the sons and daughters of the middle and upper classes has unquestionably weakened it, as Bernard Shaw recognized: how many British actors or actresses today can take King Lear, Othello, Cleopatra, or Lady Macbeth in their stride, as the unknighted troupers of the nineteenth century could?

Paradoxically, it is the simplest and least 'political' jazz which has best resisted the temptations of compromise, respectability, and official recognition. Bessie Smith, who never sang in white theatres and would not have changed her style if she had, is—like the blues—the least corrupted and corruptible part of jazz, and therefore the purest carrier of the jazz protest. (It may be significant that of all the biographies and auto-biographies of jazz artists, those of the women singers express the irreconcilable bitterness of the underdog most persistently.<sup>9</sup>) This is not because such artists are more immune to temptation. Often, indeed, the primitive and elemental musicians are far more willing than the sophisticated and emancipated ones to play what the public wants or to act as the public wants them to act. It is probably because they simply cannot sing or play any differently, being too unadaptable. If Armstrong

were to play the Purcell Trumpet Voluntary, it would still come out like the blues.

But this fact makes it harder for those who have no feeling of inferiority about jazz to champion its unique and radical merits. They can be easily accused of idealizing the simple, illiterate, and unemancipated. 'You want us to stay inferior' is a charge readily brought against those who merely want to keep jazz independent. This is inevitable. The logic of the struggle for emancipation and equality makes those who fight for it try to demonstrate two things first and foremost: (a) that they can compete successfully with those who claim superiority on their own ground, and (b) that they can abandon a way of life which has hitherto been associated with inferiority. The early feminists tried to show not only that they could pass university examinations as well as the men, but that they could do without 'feminine fripperies'—dressing elegantly, make-up, and the rest. Zionist Jews tried to show that Jews were good at farming and fighting, which had not hitherto been regarded as typically Jewish occupations, and rejected the valuable Yiddish culture of their East European ghettos as the badge of the inferior past. Those organizing African universities are highly suspicious of European advisers who suggest that they need not pay much attention to Greek and Latin. Do not the classics belong to the higher education of the Europeans, and is not the plan to cut them out merely a reflection of the desire to deprive Africans, even now, of the best education?

There is some sense in such suspicions and such rejections, however exaggerated their practical results. After all, those who kept women in inferiority did very often idealize those parts of feminine behaviour which happened not to compete with male achievements: Be pretty, sweet maid, and let who will be clever. Anti-semites never denied that Jews were clever or good at business, only that they were brave, hard-working, or honest. The champions of African inferiority are the first to idealize the 'unspoiled tribesman' as against the 'half-educated intellectual'. The cries 'Up the Pathan, down the Bengali Baboo!' 'Up the noble Beduin, down the Egyptian schoolmaster!' 'Up the brave and stupid Masai, down the corrupt Kikuyu!' ring through the history of racial oppression, just as aristocrats and employers are never tired of contrasting the simple old retainer or the loyal old operative with the

inferior specimens of the peasantry and workers on the modern political scene. It is natural, and necessary, for those who feel themselves to have been kept under to resent this, and to demonstrate their equality by doing what they have been regarded as incapable of doing.

But if it is natural that babies should be emptied with the bath water, care must be taken that they can also be put back. (There is no technical reason why they should not, unless they have been dropped on their heads in the process.) Probably they will be. Emancipated women have long stopped avoiding pretty dresses, emancipated Jews despising Yiddish stories and jokes. In due course, no doubt, emancipated American blacks will have their own 'New Orleans revival', being sufficiently distant from the old South to separate the original cultural achievement of their people from the conditions of oppression in which it took place.<sup>1</sup> Very likely by the time this happens the critics will be ready to warn them that a return to a dead past is not the same as the development of a living tradition, a warning which has hitherto had to be addressed mainly to young white musicians. In the meantime those who have no feeling of inferiority about liking or playing jazz can only continue to defend its genuine originality and achievements, even when they are combined with things which others would prefer to forget or put behind them. They can, however, also do something else. They can assist the emancipation of those who are oppressed and unprivileged, and feel themselves to be inferior. For that is probably the quickest way of making their point.

## Notes

- <sup>1</sup> R. W. S. Mendl, *The Appeal of Jazz* (London 1927), 25.
- <sup>2</sup> Reported in *Jazz Music*, December 1943.
- <sup>3</sup> *Melody Maker*, December 1926.
- <sup>4</sup> Finkelstein is the most elaborate version of the Marxist thesis, also in Iain Lang, which led to some entertaining controversies. Cf. *Jazz Music* III, 2, 1946.
- <sup>5</sup> *Jazz Music* III, 2, p. 9.
- <sup>6</sup> Mendl, 71–2.
- <sup>7</sup> Stearns, 316.
- <sup>8</sup> The best introduction to the subject is Niebuhr, *The Social Sources of Denominationalism* (Living Age Books, New York 1957).
- <sup>9</sup> Cf. Ethel Waters, *His Eyes Is on the Sparrow*, Billie Holiday and W. Dufty, *Lady Sings the Blues*.

\* Since these are subjects on which a lot of people are ultra-sensitive, it is probably necessary to state formally that anyone who thinks these descriptions of gypsies and Southern blacks or any other national and social groups represent reality, or the author's opinions, is mistaken.

† Chapters 3, 9, 10 contain some relevant material on this point.

‡ There is the excuse that black jazz musicians are much more easily victimized than white popular entertainers who have made a great deal of money. But, as the McCarthy period has shown, this is not a wholly valid excuse.

§ That intelligent impresario Norman Granz knew what he was about when he baptized his touring jazz show *Jazz at the Philharmonic*.

¶ Thus during the thirties a casual appreciation of Duke Ellington by Percy Grainger was almost invariably quoted, just as Ernest Ansermet's much more acute appreciation of Sidney Bechet in 1919 occurs in every discussion of 'traditionalist' jazz.

|| It is pleasant to record successful prophecy. Though a 'New Orleans revival' in the strict sense has not yet taken place, there has been since 1958 a striking return to 'the roots'—blues and gospel song—especially among the most race-conscious black musicians. It is precisely the most folky qualities which are now (1960) being idealized, perhaps excessively so, as 'funky' or 'soul'. However, the large tract of jazz which lies between proto-jazz and the bop revolution still remains to be discovered by many modernists.